

The Corbiani Almanac

FEBRUARY 22 - MARCH 1, 2026

*Snow to Sunshine — Sunday gravy simmers while snow falls,
and by Saturday friends gather for homemade pizza.*

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 02/22 SNOW 37°/29°	Snow day - family cooking together; Dan on call as IM	Sunday Gravy and Pasta	Thee Sacred Souls – Thee Sacred Souls
Mon 02/23 SNOW 36°/27°	School likely cancelled; Dan on call (AM); Phone screen 5-6 PM	Shepherds Pie	Curtis Harding – If Words Were Flowers
Tue 02/24 OVERCAST 35°/21°	Dan off-call afternoon; Swim lessons evening	Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce	Tom Misch – Geography
Wed 02/25 DRIZZLE 52°/32°	Elsie science potions camp 3:45-4:45	Niku Udon	Tatsuro Yamashita – For You
Thu 02/26 RAIN 43°/34°	Elsie dance camp 3:45-4:45; Dan picks up Elsie 4:30; Laura late meeting; Dan + Elsie evening	Mac and Cheese + Berries and Cream Parfaits	Vulfpeck – The Joy of Music, The Job of Real Estate
Fri 02/27 DRIZZLE 44°/32°	Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00	Linguini with Clams	Steely Dan – Aja
Sat 02/28 OVERCAST 53°/31°	Pizza party with friends!	Pizza Night (3 Pies)	Jungle – Volcano

Daily Plan

From Sunday gravy in the snow to Saturday pizza with friends

Sunday, February 22

ALL DAY | SNOW DAY COOKING

*Snow blankets Reston and the kitchen fills with slow-simmered tomato sauce.
Today is about patience.*

Sunday Gravy and Pasta

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Italian-American Sunday gravy with mixed meats slow-simmered in tomato sauce, served over rigatoni with garlic bread.

San Marzano tomatoes, Italian sausage, pork rib, rigatoni, garlic, basil, Parmigiano-Reggiano
Dan on call as Incident Manager. Snow day family cooking.

AT THE TABLE

If you were in charge of naming this snowstorm, what would you call it — and what would its personality be like?

Snow days feel like disruptions, but they're actually the unscheduled hours your family almost never gets. Resist the urge to fill them with activities or screens. Boredom is the doorway to the kind of spontaneous play and conversation you can't manufacture. If she says 'I'm bored,' try: 'Tell me more about that.' You might be surprised where it goes.

STRATEGY & SELF-MASTERY

The Calm Advantage

Pressure doesn't create character — it reveals it. This week, we explore how a deliberately calm mind becomes your most powerful tool for decision-making, whether you're managing a production incident at 2 AM or navigating a tense conversation at the dinner table. Drawing from Naval Ravikant's philosophy of equanimity, with supporting insights from Charlie Munger, Annie Duke, and Nassim Taleb.

"A calm mind, a fit body, and a house full of love. These things cannot be bought — they must be earned."

— Naval Ravikant, *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant* Happiness section

The Quiet Cockpit

There's a protocol in aviation called the 'sterile cockpit rule.' Below 10,000 feet — during takeoff and landing, the moments of highest risk — pilots are forbidden from discussing anything unrelated to the flight. No small talk about last night's game. No chatter about scheduling. Just the work in front of them. Naval Ravikant frames the same idea for daily life: 'A busy calendar and a busy mind will destroy your ability to create anything great.' (The Almanack of Naval Ravikant, Happiness section). Most people fill silence with noise — checking their phone at a red light, turning on a podcast the instant they're alone, scrolling through news while waiting for pasta water to boil. The discomfort of a quiet mind feels like a problem to solve. Naval argues it's actually the solution. Here's the mechanism: when your mind is cluttered, you default to first-available thinking. You respond to the loudest input, not the most important one. Your kid asks a question and you answer from the surface because your attention is split three ways.

A work decision lands in your lap and you choose the fastest path to make the discomfort stop. Charlie Munger put it differently but meant the same thing: 'A lot of people with high IQs are terrible investors because they've got terrible temperaments.' (Poor Charlie's Almanack, Talk 2). Temperament — the ability to stay calm in the noise — matters more than raw intelligence. The calm advantage isn't about being passive. It's about creating a few degrees of separation between stimulus and response. Viktor Frankl wrote about this space from inside a concentration camp; you can practice it while making Sunday gravy. When the pot boils over, when the toddler screams, when the PagerDuty alert fires — the person who pauses, even for two seconds, makes a fundamentally different decision than the person who reacts. This week's snow is a gift for this practice. The world slows down. Use it. Today, try one hour of sterile cockpit: no phone, no background noise, just the task in front of you and the people in the room.

"A busy calendar and a busy mind will destroy your ability to create anything great."

— Naval Ravikant, *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant*, Happiness section

Reflect: When was the last time you sat with genuine silence — no input, no screen, no music — for more than ten minutes? What came up?

GONNA WANT SECONDS · 6-8 SERVINGS · PREP 30 MIN · COOK 3-4 HOURS

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

First thing, you brown your meats. Every single piece gets a hard sear in that pot. Don't crowd it or nothing gets color. Take them out, same pot, get those onions in there. Low and slow till they're sweet. Garlic goes in, and if you can't smell it through the whole house, you didn't use enough. Tomato paste, stir it around till it gets dark. Now the San Marzanos, crush them with your hands right into the pot. Everything goes back in, bring it up to a bubble, then low. Real low. Three, four hours. You stir when you think about it. The house will tell you when it's done.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · BROWN ALL SIDES IN BATCHES, REMOVE

- 1 lb Italian sausage (*whole links*)
- 1 lb pork ribs (*separated*)
- 3 tbsp olive oil

B · SOFTEN ONION 5 MIN, GARLIC 1 MIN, TOAST PASTE 2 MIN

- 1 large onion (*diced*)
- 4 cloves garlic (*sliced*)
- 3 tbsp tomato paste

C · ADD TO POT, STIR

- 2 (28-oz) cans San Marzano tomatoes (*hand-crushed*)
- 1 cup water (*to rinse cans*)
- 4-5 leaves fresh basil

Final: return all meats → bring to simmer → cover, low heat 3-4 hours → stir occasionally → season and serve over rigatoni

VARIATIONS

Bolognese Ragu — Skip the big meat pieces, use a mix of ground beef, pork, and veal with milk and white wine for a Emilia-Romagna style meat sauce ([recipe](#))

Braciole Sunday Gravy — Add thin beef rolls stuffed with breadcrumbs, garlic, parsley, and pecorino — they simmer in the sauce like little presents ([recipe](#))

Vegetarian Sunday Sauce — Replace meats with portobello mushrooms, eggplant, and white beans — long simmer still builds the depth ([recipe](#))

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Brown the Meats in Stages — Sear meats individually in a screaming-hot Dutch oven with canola oil. Get a hard, dark crust on each piece before removing. This fond is liquid gold. 3-4 minutes per side, undisturbed.

SAUCE Parmigiano Rind in the Gravy — Drop a 3-inch piece of Parmigiano-Reggiano rind into the gravy during the last 90 minutes. It softens, releases umami, and adds silky body.

ACID Fresh Basil and Good Olive Oil Finish — Tear 8-10 fresh basil leaves over plated pasta. Finish with a thread of your best extra-virgin olive oil.

TEXTURE Garlic Butter Toast — Mix softened butter with grated garlic, flaky salt, and minced parsley. Spread on thick bread slices and broil until golden (90 seconds max).

THEE SACRED SOULS

Thee Sacred Souls

2022 · VINTAGE SOUL, CHICANO SOUL ·
TENDER, SOULFUL, WARM

San Diego soul trio channeling Motown and Chicano soul.

Vintage soul with warm organ, walking bass, and sweet falsetto.

Warm vintage soul for slow Sunday gravy cooking.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Monday, February 23

AM

5:00 PM

ON CALL

PHONE SCREEN

The snow continues lighter. Shepherd's pie is ultimate snow day food.

Shepherds Pie

BRITISH

Classic comfort: ground beef with peas and carrots under golden fork-raked mashed potato crust.

ground beef, peas, carrots, potatoes, tomato paste, red wine, Worcestershire

School likely cancelled (snow). Dan on call AM.

AT THE TABLE

Shepherd's Pie has all these layers — potato, meat, vegetables all stacked up. If you made a 'layer pie' of your perfect day, what would each layer be?

When one parent is on call or distracted by work, be honest about it: 'Dad has an important job to do today, and sometimes he'll need to step away.' Eight-year-olds handle honesty far better than vague unavailability. It also models that adults have responsibilities they take seriously — and that's something to respect, not resent.

The Panic Tax

The PagerDuty alert fires. Your heart rate spikes. Cortisol floods your system in about 300 milliseconds — far faster than your prefrontal cortex can engage. You're already reaching for your laptop before you've read the full message. This is the panic tax: the cost you pay in decision quality every time urgency hijacks your thinking. Naval Ravikant describes the trap precisely: 'In any situation in life, you only have three options. You can change it, you can accept it, or you can leave it. What is not a good option is to sit around wishing you would change it but not changing it, wishing you would leave it but not leaving it, and not accepting it.' (The Almanack of Naval Ravikant). Most people, when an alert fires or a crisis arrives, choose a secret fourth option: they panic and do something — anything — to discharge the anxiety. That something is rarely the right something. Consider what actually happens in an incident. The engineer who immediately starts restarting services feels productive. The engineer who spends ninety seconds reading logs before touching anything feels slow.

But the second engineer identifies the root cause on the first try, while the first engineer creates a cascade of new problems to troubleshoot. The panic tax isn't just the bad decision — it's the time spent cleaning up after it. Annie Duke, the former professional poker player, calls this 'resulting' — judging the quality of a decision by its outcome rather than its process (Thinking in Bets, Ch. 1). When you panic and get lucky, you reinforce the panic. When you stay calm and things go sideways anyway, you might wrongly abandon the calm approach. The skill isn't in the outcome. It's in recognizing that your first instinct under pressure is almost always your worst instinct. The practice for today is small: the next time something urgent lands in your lap — a work message, a kid's meltdown, a pot boiling over — count to five before you act. Not because the pause fixes the problem, but because it lets your prefrontal cortex catch up with your amygdala. Five seconds is the cheapest investment you'll ever make.

"In any situation in life, you only have three options. You can change it, you can accept it, or you can leave it."

— Naval Ravikant, The Almanack of Naval Ravikant

Reflect: Think about the last time you reacted immediately to a stressful situation. Would the outcome have been different if you'd waited ninety seconds before responding?

YELLOW BLISS ROAD · 4-6 SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN · COOK 45 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Boil your potatoes till they're soft, and salt that water like you mean it. Mash them with butter and milk till they're like clouds. Brown the beef good, break it up, don't leave big chunks. Onion, carrots, peas, let everything get friendly in there. Tomato paste, a good splash of Worcestershire, some broth, let it thicken up. You want it saucy, not soupy. Everything goes in the dish, potatoes on top. Now make little peaks with your fork. That's where the gold happens, those peaks get all brown and crispy. Oven, 400, wait till it's bubbling at the edges. Don't you dare take it out early.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to 400°F (200°C)

A · BOIL 15 MIN, DRAIN, MASH SMOOTH

- 2.5 lbs potatoes (*peeled, cubed*)
- 4 tbsp butter
- ½ cup milk (*warm*)
- 1 tsp salt

B · BROWN BEEF, DRAIN FAT, SAUTÉ VEG 5 MIN

- 1.5 lbs ground beef
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 onion (*diced*)
- 2 carrots (*diced*)

C · STIR IN, SIMMER 8-10 MIN UNTIL THICK

- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire
- 1 cup beef broth
- 1 cup frozen peas

Final: spread filling in baking dish → top with mashed potatoes → fork peaks for browning → bake 25-30 min until golden

VARIATIONS

Lamb Shepherd's Pie — Use ground lamb with fresh rosemary and a splash of red wine for the authentic British version (recipe)

Sweet Potato Topped — Swap regular mashed potatoes for roasted sweet potato mash with a hint of cinnamon (recipe)

Guinness Cottage Pie — Deglaze the meat with Guinness stout and add extra root veg for an Irish pub classic (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Bloom Your Tomato Paste — After browning meat, push aside and add 2 tbsp tomato paste to bare pan. Cook 2 full minutes until brick-red and sweet-smelling, then stir into meat.

SAUCE Red Wine and Worcestershire — Pour half cup dry red wine and reduce by half. Add generous tablespoon of Worcestershire with the stock.

TEXTURE Fork-Raked Top with Butter Dots — Drag fork across potato surface in crosshatch. Dot with small pieces of cold butter. Bake at 400F until ridges are deeply golden.

ACID Fresh Thyme and Flaky Salt — Scatter fresh thyme leaves and Maldon salt over golden top right out of the oven.

CURTIS HARDING

If Words Were Flowers

2021 · SOUL, GARAGE ROCK · GRITTY,
HOPEFUL, SOULFUL

Atlanta soul-rocker blending classic soul with garage rock grit.

Retro soul meets garage rock with fuzz guitar and punchy drums.

Gritty soul-rock for a cozy snow day indoors.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Tuesday, February 24

PM | OFF-CALL
EVENING | SWIM

Cold but sunny. Dan is finally off-call. Celebrate with the family's most beloved pasta.

Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce

ITALIAN

Homemade spinach egg-yolk pasta tossed in a creamy Alfredo sauce with parmesan and a touch of nutmeg.

babo pasta (spinach egg-yolk), heavy cream, butter, parmesan, garlic, nutmeg

Dan off-call Tuesday afternoon. Swim lessons evening.

AT THE TABLE

You had swim lessons tonight — what's one thing in the water that felt easier than it used to? Even a tiny thing counts.

The transition from snow days back to routine (school, swim, structured time) can feel jarring for everyone. If she's cranky or resistant tonight, it's probably not about swim — it's about missing the slow pace of the last two days. Name it gently: 'It's a lot going from snow days to a busy evening, huh?' Feeling understood is often all she needs.

The Orientation Gap

Viktor Frankl wrote: 'Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our freedom and our power to choose our response.' This is perhaps the most quoted line in all of self-help literature — and also the most misunderstood. People treat it as a platitude about patience. It's actually a technical description of how expertise works. John Boyd, the fighter pilot and military strategist, built an entire theory of conflict around this space. He called it the OODA loop: Observe, Orient, Decide, Act. The key insight — the one most people miss — is that 'Orient' is where the real work happens. Observation is passive. Decision and action are downstream. But orientation is where you bring your entire mental model to bear on what you've just seen. It's where experience, training, and calm intersect to produce clarity. Naval Ravikant arrives at the same place from a different direction: 'The classical virtues are all decision-making heuristics to make one optimize for the long term rather than for the short term.' (The Almanack of Naval Ravikant). Virtues like patience, courage, and temperance aren't moral decorations.

They're orientation tools. When you practice patience, you're training your OODA loop to hold in the Orient phase longer, resisting the pull toward premature action. Here's where it gets practical. Tonight you're off call. The snow is winding down. The instinct is to fill the evening with catch-up tasks — laundry, emails, prep for tomorrow. But the orientation gap says: before you decide how to spend your evening, spend two minutes observing how you actually feel. Tired? Restless? Relieved? The action you choose from an honest observation of your state will be fundamentally different from the action you choose out of habit or obligation. Charlie Munger practiced this religiously: 'It takes character to sit there with all that cash and to do nothing. I didn't get to where I am by going after mediocre opportunities.' (Poor Charlie's Almanack). The gap between stimulus and response isn't empty — it's where you do your best thinking. Most people rush through it because the gap feels uncomfortable. The calm advantage is learning to live there.

"Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our freedom and our power to choose our response."

— Viktor Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*

Reflect: Today, before your next decision — even a small one like what to eat or what to do next — pause and ask: what am I actually feeling right now, and is that feeling driving this choice?

THE CLEVER CARROT · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 45 MIN + 45 MIN REST · COOK 10 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

This one is simple and you are not going to mess it up. Blanch your spinach, thirty seconds, ice water, squeeze every drop out. Chop it fine. Make a mountain of flour on your board, push a well in the middle. Eggs, yolks, spinach, pour it in. Fork first, then your hands. Knead it till it is smooth as silk, ten minutes at least. For the sauce, melt butter with a clove of garlic, low heat. Pull the garlic when it is golden. Pour in the cream, let it barely simmer. Toss the pasta in with a good handful of parmesan and a scrape of nutmeg. Add pasta water if it needs loosening. Eat it while it is hot.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · BLANCH 30 SEC, ICE BATH, SQUEEZE BONE-DRY, CHOP FINE

- 3 cups (90g) fresh baby spinach (*packed*)
- 1 pot boiling water

B · WELL METHOD, INCORPORATE SPINACH-EGG MIX, KNEAD 10 MIN

- 3 cups (425g) 00 flour (*mounded*)
- 5 large egg yolks
- 2 large whole eggs
- pinch kosher salt

C · MELT BUTTER WITH GARLIC (REMOVE GARLIC), ADD CREAM, SIMMER 2 MIN, STIR IN PARMESAN OFF HEAT

- 3 Tbs butter
- 1 clove garlic (*smashed*)
- 1 cup heavy cream
- 1 cup parmesan (*finely grated*)
- pinch nutmeg (*freshly grated*)

Final: toss pasta in Alfredo sauce → add pasta water to loosen → plate and finish with parmesan

VARIATIONS

Fettuccine Alfredo Classico — Use fettuccine instead of spinach pasta for the Roman original (recipe)

Alfredo with Roasted Garlic — Swap raw garlic for a full roasted head mashed into the cream sauce (recipe)

Lemon Cream Pasta — Add lemon zest and juice to the Alfredo for brightness, finish with fresh basil (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Rest Dough 45 Minutes — Rest wrapped dough for full 45 minutes at room temp. The extra time lets gluten relax completely for thinner, more even rolling.

SAUCE Silky Alfredo Finish — Reserve 1 cup pasta water. Toss hot pasta with butter, cream, and finely grated parmesan off-heat, adding pasta water a splash at a time until glossy and clinging. A pinch of nutmeg ties it together.

TEXTURE Toasted Pine Nuts and Microplaned Parm — Toast pine nuts in dry pan until golden (3-4 min, watch carefully). Scatter over pasta. Grate Parmigiano on Microplane so it falls like snow.

ACID Lemon Zest Shower — Zest half a lemon directly over each plate using Microplane just before serving.

T O M M I S C H

Geography

2018 · JAZZ-POP, NEO-SOUL · WARM,
BREEZY, MELODIC

London multi-instrumentalist jazzy pop debut.

Jazz-pop with silky guitar, hip-hop beats, and warm keys.

Breezy guitar grooves for silky Babo pasta and Alfredo sauce.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Wednesday, February 25

3:45 PM | SCIENCE CAMP

Warming up to 52! Elsie comes home from science camp buzzing. Steaming udon is exactly what she needs.

Niku Udon

JAPANESE

Chewy udon in real dashi with soy-mirin glazed beef, onsen egg, and toppings bar.

udon noodles, kombu, katsuobushi, ribeye, soy sauce, mirin, eggs, scallions, nori

Elsie science potions camp 3:45-4:45 PM.

AT THE TABLE

You did science potions camp today! What was the wildest thing you mixed together, and what happened when you did?

Wednesday is the hump of the week, and Elsie has camp right after school. Watch for signs she's overstimulated or emotionally full by dinnertime. If she's quiet or snappy at the table, try a side-by-side activity instead of face-to-face conversation — help her chop scallions for the udon, stand next to her while she draws. Kids open up sideways.

Pressure Is Contagious

Robert Greene devotes a full chapter of *The Laws of Human Nature* to what he calls 'emotional contagion' — the fact that emotions transfer between people as reliably as a virus. You walk into a room where someone is anxious, and within minutes your shoulders tighten. Your partner comes home stressed, and by dinner you're snapping at each other over nothing. Greene's insight, drawn from Ch. 11 of *Laws of Human Nature*: we underestimate how much of what we feel actually originates outside ourselves. This is where the calm advantage becomes a superpower in relationships. Naval Ravikant frames it as a choice about identity: 'Real happiness only comes as a side-effect of peace. Most of it is going to come from acceptance, not from changing your external environment.' If you wait for the people around you to be calm before you can be calm, you'll wait forever. Someone has to go first. Watch what happens at a family dinner when one person is agitated. The conversation fragments. People talk past each other. The eight-year-old picks up the tension and starts acting out — not because she's misbehaving, but because she's the most honest mirror in the room.

Now watch what happens when the same family sits down and one person is genuinely relaxed — not performing relaxation, but actually settled. The conversation finds its rhythm. People listen longer before responding. The food tastes better because you're actually tasting it. There's a Navy SEAL concept called 'calm is contagious.' It comes from Rorke Denver, who observed that in combat, the leader's emotional state sets the ceiling for the entire team. If the leader panics, everyone panics. If the leader is steady, people can access their training. The same physics apply at a kitchen table. Tonight, Elsie comes home from science potions camp. She'll be excited, probably tired, possibly overwhelmed by the transition from structured activity to home. Your job isn't to match her energy or manage it. It's to be the steady thing in the room. Greene would say you're using emotional contagion strategically. Naval would say you're choosing peace. Either way, you're going first.

"We underestimate how much of what we feel actually originates outside ourselves."

— Robert Greene, *The Laws of Human Nature*, Ch. 11

Reflect: At dinner tonight, notice: whose emotional state is setting the temperature of the room? Is it yours?

JUST ONE COOKBOOK · 2 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 20 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

This one isn't mine, it's from another grandmother far away, but she'd tell you the same thing I would: start with good broth. Kombu goes in cold water, low heat. Pull it out before it boils or it gets slimy and bitter. Bonito flakes go in, steep two minutes, strain. That's your dashi. For the beef, slice it paper thin. Cook it fast with soy, mirin, and a little sugar. Don't overdo it or it turns into shoe leather. Noodles, hot broth, beef on top, scallions. Simple things done right.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · KOMBU IN COLD WATER, HEAT TO JUST BELOW BOIL, REMOVE KOMBU, ADD BONITO, STEEP 2 MIN, STRAIN

- 4 cups water
- 4-inch piece kombu (*wiped*)
- 20g katsuobushi (bonito)

B · SAUTÉ ONION, ADD BEEF QUICKLY, SEASON, COOK 2-3 MIN

- 8 oz ribeye (*sliced paper-thin*)
- ½ onion (*thin sliced*)
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp mirin
- ½ tsp sugar

C · COOK NOODLES PER PACKAGE

- 200g udon noodles (*fresh or frozen*)
- 2 scallions (*sliced*)

Final: season dashi with 2 tbsp mirin + 1-2 tbsp soy + ½ tsp salt → noodles in bowls → ladle hot broth over → top with beef and scallions

VARIATIONS

Curry Udon (Kare Udon) — Thicken the dashi broth with Japanese curry roux for a warming, spiced version (recipe)

Sukiyaki Style — Cook the beef and onions sukiyaki-style with sake, soy, and sugar, then serve over udon in lighter broth (recipe)

Kimchi Udon — Add fermented kimchi and gochugaru to the broth for a Korean-Japanese fusion bowl with funky heat (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Build Real Dashi — Bring 4 cups water with 4-inch kombu piece to just below boil (never boil kombu). Remove, add packed cup of katsuobushi, steep 5 min, strain. Season with soy, mirin, pinch of sugar.

SAUCE Soy-Mirin Glazed Beef — Slice beef paper-thin against grain. Sear in batches 30 sec per side. Deglaze with 2 tbsp each soy and mirin. Reduce to glaze (30 sec), toss beef to coat.

TEMPERATURE Onsen Egg — Hold water at 167F for 13 minutes with eggs. Transfer to ice water. Crack over finished udon - white barely set, yolk completely liquid.

TEXTURE Toppings Bar — Set out shichimi togarashi, torn nori, sliced scallions, and tenkasu (crispy tempura bits) for everyone to customize.

TATSURO YAMASHITA

For You

1982 · JAPANESE CITY POP · ROMANTIC,
BREEZY, GROOVY

The king of Japanese city pop. Lush and melodic.

Lush synth-pop with funky bass lines and bright horns.

Japanese city pop for Niku Udon night.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Thursday, February 26

3:45 PM	DANCE CAMP
4:30 PM	PICKUP
EVE	DAN+ELSIE

Rainy and 43. Laura has a late meeting — tonight belongs to Dan and Elsie.

Mac and Cheese + Berries and Cream Parfaits

AMERICAN

Three-cheese baked mac with panko crust, fruit, and berries & cream parfaits.

sharp cheddar, Gruyere, American cheese, macaroni, panko, strawberries, blueberries, whipped cream

Elsie dance camp 3:45-4:45. Dan pickup 4:30. Laura late meeting. Dan + Elsie evening.

AT THE TABLE

It's a Dan-and-Elsie night! If you could plan the perfect evening for just the two of us — anything goes — what would it look like, hour by hour?

One-on-one time with a parent is different from family time, and it should feel different. Dan — let yourself be a little sillier, a little more relaxed than usual. Share something about your own day that you wouldn't normally mention at a family dinner. Eight-year-olds are starting to understand that their parents are real people with inner lives, and small revelations ('I had a hard meeting today but then I saw a funny meme') build a bridge she'll walk across for years.

Decide Less, Decide Better

Annie Duke, former professional poker player, has a devastating insight about how most people make decisions. In *Thinking in Bets* (Ch. 3), she observes that we treat every decision as if it has equal weight. Should I take this job? What should I have for lunch? Should I check my email? The decision machinery fires the same way for all three, which means by the time you face the important decision, your machinery is exhausted from grinding through trivia. Naval Ravikant puts it more bluntly: 'If you want to make the wrong decision, ask everyone.' The instinct to crowdsource decisions — texting three friends, reading five reviews, asking your partner what they think about something only you can decide — is really an instinct to avoid the discomfort of choosing. Each consultation feels responsible but actually depletes the cognitive resources you need for the decision itself. Charlie Munger practiced aggressive decision elimination. His famous 'too hard' pile wasn't laziness — it was strategic. 'Recognize reality even when you don't like it — especially when you don't like it.' (Poor Charlie's Almanack). If a decision was too complex to evaluate clearly, he put it aside.

Not every problem deserves your analytical attention. Some problems solve themselves if you leave them alone. Others aren't actually your problems. Here's what this looks like tonight. Dan and Elsie have the house to themselves — Laura's at her late meeting, and the menu is mac and cheese followed by berries and cream parfaits. The temptation is to optimize the evening: plan an activity, structure the time, make it 'special.' But the calm advantage says: reduce the decisions. The dinner is decided. The dessert is decided. Let the evening be simple. When you eliminate the small decisions, you create space for the one thing that actually matters — being present with your kid without an agenda. James Clear frames this as environment design (*Atomic Habits*, Ch. 6): the best way to make good decisions isn't to have more willpower — it's to design your life so you face fewer decisions in the first place. The meal plan, the prep-ahead list, the weekly rhythm — these aren't organizational tools. They're decision-elimination tools that preserve your calm for the moments that actually require it.

"If you want to make the wrong decision, ask everyone."

— Naval Ravikant, *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant*

Reflect: How many decisions did you make today that didn't actually need your attention? What would your day look like if you put half of them in the 'too hard' pile?

EPIC DISHES · 4-6 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 30 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Cook the pasta two minutes short, it finishes in the oven. Melt your butter, whisk in the flour, let it cook a minute so it doesn't taste like paste. Milk goes in slow, keep whisking. When it's thick like cream, off the heat. Three cheeses: cheddar for flavor, Gruyère because we have standards, and American because it melts like a dream. Stir till it's glossy. Pasta in, into the dish. Panko on top with melted butter. Oven till it's bubbling at the edges and gold on top. See? Not so hard.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

*Preheat oven to 350°F (175°C)***A · DRAIN, RESERVE ½ CUP PASTA WATER**

- 1 lb elbow macaroni (*cook 2 min short of al dente*)

B · ROUX 1 MIN, WHISK IN MILK, THICKEN 5 MIN

- 4 tbsp butter
- ¼ cup flour
- 3 cups whole milk (*warm*)
- ½ tsp mustard powder

C · STIR INTO SAUCE OFF HEAT UNTIL MELTED

- 2 cups sharp cheddar (*shredded*)
- 1 cup Gruyère (*shredded*)
- 4 oz American cheese (*torn*)

D · TOSS TOGETHER FOR TOPPING

- 1 cup panko
- 2 tbsp butter (*melted*)

Final: combine pasta + cheese sauce → pour into baking dish → top with panko mixture → bake 25-30 min until golden and bubbly

VARIATIONS

Lobster Mac and Cheese — Fold in chunks of steamed lobster tail and add a pinch of smoked paprika for a luxurious upgrade (recipe)

Truffle Mac and Cheese — Drizzle truffle oil and fold in sautéed mushrooms for an earthy, indulgent twist (recipe)

Buffalo Chicken Mac — Mix in shredded buffalo chicken and top with blue cheese crumbles for game-day energy (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Three-Cheese Blend — Use 50% sharp cheddar, 30% Gruyere, 20% American cheese. The American contains sodium citrate which prevents grainy sauce.

TEXTURE Buttered Panko Crust — Toss 1 cup panko with 2 tbsp melted butter, pinch garlic powder, 1 tbsp grated Parm. Spread over mac, bake 375F until deeply golden and shattery.

SAUCE Mustard Powder in the Roux — Whisk 1 tsp dry mustard powder and pinch cayenne into the flour when making roux. Cook 1 minute before adding milk.

PREPARATION Undercook Pasta by 3 Minutes — Boil macaroni 3 minutes short of package time. It finishes cooking in sauce and oven. Overcooked noodles turn to mush.

VULFPECK

The Joy of Music, The Job of Real Estate

2020 · MINIMALIST FUNK · PLAYFUL, WARM,
JOYFUL

Michigan funk collective with playful grooves.

Lo-fi funk with tight pocket grooves and slap bass.

Playful funk for Elsie kid night.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Friday, February 27

4:30 PM | YAT 4:30-6

Sunny, 44. While Elsie is at YAT, prep the clams. Steely Dan, a glass of Vermentino, perfection.

Linguini with Clams

ITALIAN

Classic linguini alle vongole: clams in white wine with garlic three ways and pangritata.

linguini, littleneck clams, garlic, white wine, olive oil, breadcrumbs, lemon, parsley

Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00 PM.

AT THE TABLE

You just came from YAT — if you had to perform one scene from your life this week as a little play, which moment would you pick?

After a week this full — snow days, on-call stress, camps every afternoon, swim — Friday night is not the time for catching up on anything. It's the time for being low-energy together. If the house is messy, leave it. If there's homework, it can wait until tomorrow. Your presence tonight matters more than your productivity.

The Case for Useful Tension

Here's the contrarian take: Nassim Taleb argues that systems — including people — don't just tolerate stress; they require it. 'Wind extinguishes a candle and energizes fire. Likewise with randomness, uncertainty, chaos: you want to use them, not hide from them.' (Antifragile, Prologue). If the calm advantage is real, does that mean we should seek out maximum tranquility? Should we insulate ourselves from all pressure? Absolutely not. And this is where a lot of self-help advice goes wrong. The goal isn't to eliminate stress — it's to choose your stress wisely and meet it from a calm foundation. There's a meaningful difference between chaos that happens to you and challenge that you walk toward. The first depletes; the second strengthens. Taleb calls this antifragility: the property of getting stronger from disorder, rather than merely surviving it. Naval Ravikant resolves the apparent contradiction: 'A rational person can find peace by cultivating indifference to things outside their control.' The key word is 'outside.' You don't cultivate indifference to your craft, your relationships, or your health.

You cultivate indifference to other people's opinions, market fluctuations, and whether your flight is delayed. The calm advantage is selective. Consider today's schedule. Elsie has YAT from 4:30 to 6:00. You have a window to prep the linguini with clams — a dish that requires precise timing. The clams need to steam exactly right; the pasta needs to finish in the broth. This is useful tension. It demands your full attention, rewards your skill, and produces something beautiful. Compare this to the useless tension of checking Slack every four minutes to see if anyone needs something. Munger's framework for this was characteristically blunt: 'Knowing what you don't know is more useful than being brilliant.' (Poor Charlie's Almanack). The calm person isn't the person with zero stress. It's the person who knows which stress to engage and which to release. Tonight, engage with the clams. Release everything else.

"Wind extinguishes a candle and energizes fire. Likewise with randomness, uncertainty, chaos: you want to use them, not hide from them."

— Nassim Taleb, Antifragile, Prologue

Reflect: What's one source of tension in your life that's actually making you stronger? And one that's just noise you could release?

SIP AND FEAST · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 30 MIN (PURGE CLAMS) · COOK 15 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

First, and I cannot stress this enough, soak your clams in salty water. Thirty minutes minimum. Any sand in your pasta and dinner is ruined. Heat olive oil, good olive oil, and let the garlic go golden. Not brown, golden. A pinch of red pepper if you like. In go all the clams, pour the wine over, lid on tight. Five minutes, they open. Take them out right away. Let that beautiful juice reduce a little. The pasta goes in that juice with a splash of pasta water, toss it until the noodles drink everything up. Clams back in, parsley, a thread of your best olive oil. No cheese. Never cheese with clams.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · HEAT OIL, SAUTÉ GARLIC 1 MIN, ADD CLAMS + WINE, COVER 5-7 MIN

- 2 lbs littleneck clams (*scrubbed, purged 30 min*)
- ½ cup extra-virgin olive oil
- 3-4 cloves garlic (*thinly sliced*)
- ½ tsp red pepper flakes
- ¾ cup dry white wine

B · DRAIN, RESERVE 1 CUP PASTA WATER

- 1 lb linguine (*cook 1 min short of al dente*)

C · READY FOR FINISHING

- ¼ cup fresh Italian parsley (*chopped*)
- drizzle finishing olive oil

Final: remove clams from broth, reduce broth 2 min → add pasta to broth, toss with pasta water → return clams, add parsley + oil → serve immediately, no cheese

VARIATIONS

Linguine alle Vongole in Rosso — Add San Marzano tomatoes to the clam sauce for the red version — equally classic in Naples (recipe)

Spaghetti with Mussels — Swap clams for mussels and add a splash of cream and fresh tarragon for a French-Italian crossover (recipe)

Clams Casino Pasta — Top with crispy breadcrumbs, bacon bits, and roasted peppers for an Italian-American bar-style twist (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Finish Pasta in Clam Broth — Steam clams open first, reserve and strain all liquor. Cook linguini 2 min short, finish directly in clam broth with pasta water. Starch-clam liquor creates silky, briny sauce.

SAUCE Garlic Three Ways — (1) Thinly sliced garlic cooked golden in olive oil as base. (2) One clove grated raw into sauce at end. (3) Garlic-infused breadcrumbs as finish. Three textures, three intensities.

TEXTURE Pangritata (Crispy Garlic Breadcrumbs) — Toast coarse breadcrumbs in olive oil with minced garlic, red pepper flakes, and lemon zest until deeply golden. Scatter over plated pasta.

ACID White Wine Reduction and Lemon Finish — Use dry Vermentino or Pinot Grigio, reduce by two-thirds before adding clam broth. Finish with lemon squeeze and rough-chopped parsley.

STEELY DAN

Aja

1977 · JAZZ-ROCK · SOPHISTICATED, COOL,
SARDONIC

Jazz-rock perfection with sardonic storytelling.

Jazz-rock fusion with session perfection.

Sophisticated jazz-rock for elegant clam pasta.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Saturday, February 28

EVENING | PIZZA PARTY!

Beautiful 53 and sunny. Friends gather for three homemade pies and Jungle turns the kitchen into a dance floor.

Pizza Night (3 Pies)

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Three pies: Buffalo Chicken White, Cheese & Pepperoni with Hot Honey, Mac & Cheese Pizza.

bread flour, yeast, buffalo sauce, chicken, Gorgonzola, capers, mozzarella, pepperoni, honey

Pizza party with friends! Dough started Wednesday.

AT THE TABLE

You're the host tonight! If you could give our pizza party a theme — like a restaurant name and a vibe — what would it be?

When friends are over, you'll see a different version of Elsie — her 'social self.' She might be louder, bossier, sillier, or more reserved than she is at home. All of that is normal. She's trying on different ways of being in the world, and a pizza party is a safe lab for that. Don't correct her social behavior in front of friends. If something needs addressing, save it for the quiet debrief at bedtime.

The Host's Advantage

The best incident managers and the best dinner party hosts share a trait that looks effortless but isn't: they make everyone else feel calmer just by being in the room. Watch a great host work. They don't rush. They don't apologize for the food. They don't hover. They move through their own kitchen like they belong there, and that quiet confidence becomes the emotional scaffolding for the entire evening. Naval Ravikant captured why this works: 'A calm mind, a fit body, and a house full of love. These things cannot be bought — they must be earned.' (The Almanack of Naval Ravikant, Happiness section). The host's advantage isn't a performance. It's the accumulated result of preparation meeting presence. You made the dough three days ago. You prepped the toppings this afternoon. The buffalo chicken is sauced, the pepperoni is sliced, the mac and cheese pizza is ready to assemble. So when friends arrive, you're not scrambling — you're hosting. That difference changes everything. Robert Greene would recognize this as a form of strategic authority (The 48 Laws of Power, Law 4: Always Say Less Than Necessary).

The host who over-explains the menu, who narrates every step of the cooking process, who seeks validation for their choices, actually transfers their anxiety to the guests. The host who puts a drink in your hand, points you toward the music, and goes back to stretching dough — that person makes you feel like everything is going to be exactly right. Here's the integration point for the whole week. Sunday you practiced the quiet cockpit. Monday you learned the panic tax. Tuesday you found the orientation gap. Wednesday you understood emotional contagion. Thursday you eliminated unnecessary decisions. Friday you engaged with useful tension. Tonight, all of it converges. You're hosting friends, making three pizzas from dough you fermented for three days, with Jungle's Volcano on the speakers and your kid running between the kitchen and the living room. The calm advantage was never about sitting still. It was about doing hard things from a place of steadiness. The pizza doesn't care about your philosophy. But the people eating it can feel the difference between a host who's frantic and one who's free.

"A calm mind, a fit body, and a house full of love. These things cannot be bought — they must be earned."

— Naval Ravikant, The Almanack of Naval Ravikant, Happiness section

Reflect: Looking back at this week, which moment were you most calm? What made that possible — and how could you build more of those conditions into next week?

BAKING STEEL · 3 PIES SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN + 72 HOURS COLD FERMENT · COOK 6-8 MIN PER PIE

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Three days before, you make this dough. Flour, water, a whisper of yeast, salt. Mix it, knead it a little, into the fridge. Three days. The yeast does slow, beautiful work. On pizza night, pull it out three hours early. Divide it into three balls. Stretch with your hands, never a rolling pin. For the buffalo chicken: shredded chicken, hot sauce, blue cheese, mozzarella. For the classic: good sauce, mozzarella, pepperoni on top so the edges curl. The mac and cheese one is ridiculous but the kids will love you forever. Hot oven, as hot as it goes. Six, seven minutes. Watch it.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to Oven max (500-550°F) with pizza stone/steel

A · MIX FLOUR+YEAST, ADD WATER, REST 30 MIN, ADD SALT, KNEAD

- 500g bread flour
- 350g water (*room temp*)
- 16g sea salt
- 1g (¼ tsp) instant yeast

B · TOSS CHICKEN IN SAUCE (PIE 1 TOPPING)

- 1 cup buffalo sauce
- 2 cups shredded chicken (*cooked*)
- ½ cup gorgonzola (*crumbled*)

C · CLASSIC ASSEMBLY (PIE 2 TOPPING)

- 1 cup pizza sauce (*San Marzano*)
- 2 cups mozzarella (*shredded*)
- ½ cup pepperoni

D · SPREAD ON DOUGH (PIE 3 TOPPING)

- 2 cups mac and cheese (*cooked, cooled*)
- 1 cup mozzarella (*shredded*)
- drizzle truffle oil (*optional*)

Final: bulk rise 1-2 hrs, cold ferment 72 hrs → divide into 3 balls, warm 3 hrs → stretch by hand, add toppings → bake on stone/steel 6-8 min each

VARIATIONS

Detroit-Style Pan Pizza — Press dough into an oiled steel pan, cheese to the edges for caramelized corners, sauce on top (recipe)

Grilled Pizza — Stretch dough, grill one side directly on grates, flip, add toppings, cover to melt (recipe)

Pizza Bianca with Potatoes — Skip tomato sauce entirely — olive oil, thinly sliced potatoes, rosemary, sea salt on the crust (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION 72-Hour Cold Fermented Dough — Make dough 3 days ahead. Bread flour, 65% hydration, 1/4 tsp yeast per 500g flour, 3% salt. Refrigerate 72 hours. Pull out 2 hours before baking.

SAUCE Blue Cheese Bechamel for Buffalo Pie — Make light bechamel with butter, flour, milk. Off heat, crumble in Gorgonzola dolce until melted. Spread as base. Top with buffalo chicken, mozz, capers, thin celery slices.

TEXTURE Cup-and-Char Pepperoni — Use natural-casing pepperoni sliced thick. The casing causes edges to curl into cups that pool with rendered spicy fat. Place on top of cheese.

TEMPERATURE Hot Honey Drizzle — After pulling pepperoni pie from oven, drizzle with hot honey (3 tbsp honey + 1 tsp red pepper flakes, warmed).

JUNGLE

Volcano

2023 · FUNK-DISCO, ELECTRONIC SOUL ·
DANCEABLE, EUPHORIC, WARM

London funk-electronic duo with irresistible grooves.

Modern funk-disco with layered synths and driving beats.

Pure party energy for pizza night with friends.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, and beverages

Appetizers

Banana Nut Bread

Moist banana bread with walnuts from brown bananas.

Salads

COMPOSED DINNER

Italian Chopped Salad

Romaine, salami, provolone, chickpeas, pepperoncini, red onion, Italian vinaigrette.

Beverage Pairings

Smoked Maple Old Fashioned

Bourbon, maple syrup, bitters. Snow day warmth.

Warmth for rich slow-cooked meats.

Hot Toddy

Whiskey, honey, lemon, nutmeg.

The ultimate snow day drink.

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Parenting Corner

Snowed In, Opened Up

The week starts with snow trapping everyone indoors — and that's the gift. The unstructured togetherness of a snow day is exactly the kind of slow time an 8-year-old secretly craves, even if she'd never say so. As the weather thaws and the week fills with camps, swim, and a pizza party, the warmth you build in those first quiet days carries forward like embers.

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — SUNDAY GRAVY AND PASTA

"If you were in charge of naming this snowstorm, what would you call it — and what would its personality be like?"

Snow days feel like disruptions, but they're actually the unscheduled hours your family almost never gets. Resist the urge to fill them with activities or screens. Boredom is the doorway to the kind of spontaneous play and conversation you can't manufacture. If she says 'I'm bored,' try: 'Tell me more about that.' You might be surprised where it goes.

SUNDAY — SUNDAY GRAVY AND PASTA

"What's the secret to making really good pasta sauce? If you had to teach someone who'd never cooked before, what would you tell them first?"

Snow days feel like disruptions, but they're actually the unscheduled hours your family almost never gets. Resist the urge to fill them with activities or screens. Boredom is the doorway to the kind of spontaneous play and conversation you can't manufacture. If she says 'I'm bored,' try: 'Tell me more about that.' You might be surprised where it goes.

MONDAY — SHEPHERDS PIE

"Shepherd's Pie has all these layers — potato, meat, vegetables all stacked up. If you made a 'layer pie' of your perfect day, what would each layer be?"

When one parent is on call or distracted by work, be honest about it: 'Dad has an important job to do today, and sometimes he'll need to step away.' Eight-year-olds handle honesty far better than vague unavailability. It also models that adults have responsibilities they take seriously — and that's something to respect, not resent.

MONDAY — SHEPHERDS PIE

"Dad's working as the Incident Manager today, which means he helps fix problems when things go wrong. What do you think would be the hardest part of that job?"

When one parent is on call or distracted by work, be honest about it: 'Dad has an important job to do today, and sometimes he'll need to step away.' Eight-year-olds handle honesty far better than vague unavailability. It also models that adults have responsibilities they take seriously — and that's something to respect, not resent.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA

"You had swim lessons tonight — what's one thing in the water that felt easier than it used to? Even a tiny thing counts."

The transition from snow days back to routine (school, swim, structured time) can feel jarring for everyone. If she's cranky or resistant tonight, it's probably not about swim — it's about missing the slow pace of the last two days. Name it gently: 'It's a lot going from snow days to a busy evening, huh?' Feeling understood is often all she needs.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA

"If you could swim anywhere in the world — an ocean, a lake, a pool on top of a mountain — where would you pick, and who would you bring?"

The transition from snow days back to routine (school, swim, structured time) can feel jarring for everyone. If she's cranky or resistant tonight, it's probably not about swim — it's about missing the slow pace of the last two days. Name it gently: 'It's a lot going from snow days to a busy evening, huh?' Feeling understood is often all she needs.

WEDNESDAY — NIKU UDON

"You did science potions camp today! What was the wildest thing you mixed together, and what happened when you did?"

Conversation Starters (continued)

WEDNESDAY — NIKU UDON

"Udon noodles come from Japan, where they slurp their noodles really loudly because it means the food is delicious. If our family had a food tradition from another country, what would you want it to be?"

Wednesday is the hump of the week, and Elsie has camp right after school. Watch for signs she's overstimulated or emotionally full by dinnertime. If she's quiet or snappy at the table, try a side-by-side activity instead of face-to-face conversation — help her chop scallions for the udon, stand next to her while she draws. Kids open up sideways.

THURSDAY — MAC AND CHEESE

"It's a Dan-and-Elsie night! If you could plan the perfect evening for just the two of us — anything goes — what would it look like, hour by hour?"

One-on-one time with a parent is different from family time, and it should feel different. Dan — let yourself be a little sillier, a little more relaxed than usual. Share something about your own day that you wouldn't normally mention at a family dinner. Eight-year-olds are starting to understand that their parents are real people with inner lives, and small revelations ('I had a hard meeting today but then I saw a funny meme') build a bridge she'll walk across for years.

THURSDAY — MAC AND CHEESE

"Berries and cream for dessert — if you could invent a brand-new dessert that doesn't exist yet, what would it be called and what would be in it?"

One-on-one time with a parent is different from family time, and it should feel different. Dan — let yourself be a little sillier, a little more relaxed than usual. Share something about your own day that you wouldn't normally mention at a family dinner. Eight-year-olds are starting to understand that their parents are real people with inner lives, and small revelations ('I had a hard meeting today but then I saw a funny meme') build a bridge she'll walk across for years.

FRIDAY — LINGUINI WITH CLAMS

"You just came from YAT — if you had to perform one scene from your life this week as a little play, which moment would you pick?"

After a week this full — snow days, on-call stress, camps every afternoon, swim — Friday night is not the time for catching up on anything. It's the time for being low-energy together. If the house is messy, leave it. If there's homework, it can wait until tomorrow. Your presence tonight matters more than your productivity.

FRIDAY — LINGUINI WITH CLAMS

"Clams live in shells at the bottom of the ocean. If you could live inside any animal's home for a day — a bird's nest, a beaver dam, a beehive — which would you choose and why?"

After a week this full — snow days, on-call stress, camps every afternoon, swim — Friday night is not the time for catching up on anything. It's the time for being low-energy together. If the house is messy, leave it. If there's homework, it can wait until tomorrow. Your presence tonight matters more than your productivity.

SATURDAY — PIZZA NIGHT

"You're the host tonight! If you could give our pizza party a theme — like a restaurant name and a vibe — what would it be?"

When friends are over, you'll see a different version of Elsie — her 'social self.' She might be louder, bossier, sillier, or more reserved than she is at home. All of that is normal. She's trying on different ways of being in the world, and a pizza party is a safe lab for that. Don't correct her social behavior in front of friends. If something needs addressing, save it for the quiet debrief at bedtime.

SATURDAY — PIZZA NIGHT

"What's one thing about each of your friends that you think is really cool — something not everyone would notice about them?"

When friends are over, you'll see a different version of Elsie — her 'social self.' She might be louder, bossier, sillier, or more reserved than she is at home. All of that is normal. She's trying on different ways of being in the world, and a pizza party is a safe lab for that. Don't correct her social behavior in front of friends. If something needs addressing,

Nudges

The Snow Day Deposit

Sunday and Monday are gift days — unscheduled, unhurried, trapped together by weather. These are rare.

Use the snow days to build a 'connection deposit' that carries through the busy rest of the week. Do one thing that's entirely Elsie-led: she picks the activity, the timing, and the rules. It could be baking, a craft, a game, or just lying on the floor and talking. The key is that you follow — no steering, no improving, no teaching.

1. Say: 'The snow gave us extra time together. You're in charge — what should we do?'
 2. Set a timer for 20 minutes so she knows the time is real and protected
 3. When the timer goes off, say: 'That was my favorite part of today.' Mean it.
-

The Thursday Night Tradition

Dan and Elsie have a rare one-on-one evening while Laura works late. This is too good to waste on screens.

Start a 'Thursday Night Thing' — not a one-time event, but the beginning of a tradition. It doesn't matter what the thing is (this week it might be making berries and cream and watching a movie). What matters is that Dan says: 'This was great. Let's make Thursday nights our thing when we can.' Traditions give 8-year-olds a sense of stability and specialness.

1. After dinner, ask: 'So what's our plan tonight? Your call.'
 2. At the end of the evening, say: 'I really liked tonight. Should Thursday be our thing?'
 3. Let her name it — 'Dan and Elsie Thursdays' or whatever she invents. The name makes it real.
-

The Camp Debrief Reframe

Elsie has three different camps this week (science potions, dance, YAT). That's a lot of new input for an 8-year-old brain.

Instead of asking 'How was camp?' (which gets you 'fine'), try: 'Tell me one thing that surprised you today.' Surprise is a more specific emotion than 'good' or 'fun,' and it forces her to scan her memory for something real. If she says 'nothing,' follow up with: 'Nothing?! Not even a tiny thing?' — said with genuine playful curiosity, not interrogation.

1. Swap 'How was it?' for 'What surprised you?' for one whole week
 2. If she gives a real answer, ask one follow-up: 'Why do you think that surprised you?'
 3. Don't push for more than two exchanges — let the conversation breathe and she may come back to it later
-

Reflection

Rosie Revere, Engineer by Andrea Beaty

A picture book she may have outgrown — or think she has — but will love being read aloud during a snow day. It's about a girl who builds inventions and learns that failure is just the first step. Perfect for a week where she's doing science potions camp and building things.

Ties directly to the science potions camp on Wednesday and the week's theme of opening up through experimentation. Read it together on Sunday or Monday during the snow, and when she comes home from science camp, you can say: 'So — did you have a Rosie Revere moment today?'

Somewhere this week — maybe during the snow day chaos, maybe during Thursday night's quiet — she's going to say or do something that shows you who she's becoming, not just who she is right now. It might be a flash of empathy, a surprisingly sharp observation, or the way she takes charge of the pizza party. When it happens, pause. Tell her you noticed. And then, later, when she's asleep, let yourself feel the weight of the fact that you're doing this well. The very fact that you're thinking about how to connect with her this week means she already has what she needs most: parents who are paying attention.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

The Stoic Guide

RESILIENCE

The Inner Fire

Late winter tests our patience — the cold lingers, responsibilities pile up, and spring feels far away. The Stoics taught that we carry an inner fire: the power to choose calm over chaos, presence over worry, and warmth over withdrawal. This week, as snow gives way to thaw and stress gives way to celebration, we tend that flame together.

"Men look for retreats for themselves, the country, the sea-shore, the hills; and you yourself, too, are peculiarly accustomed to feel the same want. Yet all this is very unlike a philosopher, when you may at any hour you please retreat into yourself."

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 4.3

Late winter tests our patience — the cold lingers, responsibilities pile up, and spring feels far away. The Stoics taught that we carry an inner fire: the power to choose calm over chaos, presence over worry, and warmth over withdrawal. This week, as snow gives way to thaw and stress gives way to celebration, we tend that flame together.

SUNDAY A Quiet Place Inside

The snow is falling and the world slows down. Marcus Aurelius governed an entire empire, yet he found his greatest refuge not in a palace but in his own thoughts. Today, as snow blankets everything outside, try treating the stillness as a gift — a chance to settle into the quiet place you always carry with you. You don't need a vacation to find peace; you just need a pause.

What does 'quiet' feel like to you? Where in your day could you create even two minutes of real stillness?

"Nowhere does a man retreat into more quiet or more privacy than into his own mind." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 4.3

MONDAY The Line You Draw

School is cancelled, the on-call phone might ring at any moment, and the day's plans have dissolved. Epictetus — a man who was once enslaved — built his entire philosophy around one idea: know what you control and release what you don't. You can't control the snow, the school district, or when an incident fires. But you can control how you show up for your family in the moments between alerts. That's where your power lives today.

Draw a line down a page. On the left, write what's stressing you today. On the right, write only the parts you can actually influence. How does the right side feel different?

"Some things are under our control, while others are not under our control. Under our control are conception, choice, desire, aversion, and, in a word, everything that is our own doing." — Epictetus, Enchiridion 1

TUESDAY Through, Not Around

The final stretch of on-call duty. Marcus Aurelius didn't write about obstacles from a place of comfort — he wrote from a military camp on the frozen Danube frontier, facing both enemies and plague. His insight was radical: the obstacle isn't blocking the path, it is the path. Every stressful incident you manage today is building the very resilience you'll rely on tomorrow. The fire inside grows stronger with each challenge it absorbs.

Think of a hard thing you pushed through recently. What strength did you discover in yourself that you didn't know you had?

Reflections & Practice

WEDNESDAY The Thaw

The temperature is climbing and the worst of the week's stress is behind you. How much of this week's worry actually came true? Seneca noticed two thousand years ago that we rehearse disasters that never arrive, and the suffering we invent often dwarfs the real thing. Today, as the world literally thaws, let your mind thaw too. Notice how much lighter you feel when you stop bracing for impact.

What were you most worried about earlier this week? How much of that worry turned out to be unnecessary?

"There are more things likely to frighten us than there are to crush us; we suffer more often in imagination than in reality." — Seneca, Letters to Lucilius 13.4

THURSDAY Tending the Fire

With the hardest part of the week behind you, today is about what you feed your mind. Marcus Aurelius understood that we become what we think about — not once, but repeatedly. If you spend the day replaying Monday's stress, your soul takes on that color. If you choose to notice one kind word, one warm meal, one moment of laughter, your mind is dyed in those colors instead. The inner fire needs good fuel.

If you could choose one 'color' for your thoughts today — calm, gratitude, curiosity, courage — which would you pick? What's one small thing you can do to practice it?

"As are your repeated imaginations so will your mind be, for the soul is dyed by its imaginations." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 5.16

FRIDAY The Gift of Today

Friday energy pulls us forward — into weekend plans, pizza party excitement, next week's to-do list. Seneca warns that living in the future is a quiet form of not living at all. The pizza party will be wonderful tomorrow, but today has its own unrepeatable gifts: a Friday afternoon, a week survived, the simple satisfaction of having made it through. Don't rush past this moment to get to the next one.

What is one thing about today — just today — that you're grateful for? Say it out loud at dinner tonight.

"The greatest hindrance to living is expectancy, which depends upon the morrow and wastes to-day." — Seneca, On the Shortness of Life 9

SATURDAY The Shared Table

The pizza is in the oven and the people you love are gathered close. Seneca — often remembered as stern — wrote tenderly about human connection. We are not built for isolation; we are built for shared tables and laughter and the beautiful mess of life together. This week tested your patience and resilience, but it ends here: warm food, warm company, and the inner fire you carried through it all.

At the pizza party tonight, ask everyone at the table: 'What was the hardest part of your week, and what got you through it?'

"We are the parts of one great body. Nature produced us related to one another, since she created us from the same source and to the same end. She engendered in us mutual affection, and made us prone to friendships." — Seneca, Letters to Lucilius 95.52

The Fire Inside Drawing

After dinner one evening, give everyone a piece of paper and ask them to draw what their 'inner fire' looks like today. Is it a roaring bonfire? A tiny candle? A glowing ember? Share your drawings and talk about what makes your fire grow bigger and what makes it shrink.

Marcus Aurelius compared the mind to a fire in Meditations 4.1: 'A bright fire masters what falls into it, whereby a little taper would

Bedtime Story

The Great Chicken Liver Caper

The Great Chicken Liver Caper

Fat snowflakes tumbled past the kitchen window like tiny parachuters who'd lost their maps. Chelsie pressed her nose against the glass and grinned. A snow day! No school, no homework, just a whole glorious day at Momma Karen's house.

"Lunchtime, my darling!" Momma Karen sang from the kitchen, sliding a plate across the counter with the pride of a queen presenting a crown jewel.

Chelsie looked down. On the plate sat a mound of grayish-brown paste on toast.

"What... is that?" Chelsie whispered.

"Chicken liver spread! My absolute favorite since I was your age. One bite and you'll be hooked."

Chelsie's sock puppet, Mr. Bugles — who lived permanently on her left hand and had googly eyes that rattled when he talked — leaned toward the plate and sniffed.

"Lady, that looks like something the cat already decided against," Mr. Bugles announced.

"MR. BUGLES!" Chelsie gasped, trying not to laugh.

Momma Karen put her hands on her hips. "Fine. You don't like it plain? Just wait."

Momma Karen disappeared into the kitchen like a scientist entering her laboratory. Pots clanged. The refrigerator opened and closed three times. Something whirred.

She returned holding the same toast — now topped with a magnificent mountain of whipped cream and a cherry on top.

"There!" Momma Karen beamed. "Everyone loves whipped cream."

Chelsie took the tiniest bite in the history of tiny bites. Her face scrunched. It tasted like a sundae had gotten into a fight with a barnyard and both of them lost.

"It's... creative," Chelsie said carefully.

Mr. Bugles had no such manners. "ALERT! ALERT! My taste buds are filing a police report!" He flopped dramatically onto the table. "Someone call 9-1-1 and ask for the food crimes division!"

Momma Karen snatched the plate back. "Okay, okay. Whipped cream was too simple. I need to think BIGGER."

Outside, the snow was piling up past the first porch step. Chelsie watched Momma Karen march back to the kitchen with the determination of a general heading into battle, and she had a feeling this was far from over.

Twenty minutes later, the kitchen smelled like chocolate mixed with something... mysterious.

Momma Karen emerged carrying an actual cake. It had chocolate frosting, rainbow sprinkles, and a little flag on top that read "YUM" in wobbly letters she'd written with icing.

"Chicken liver chocolate cake!" she announced triumphantly. "I mixed the spread right into the batter. You can't even taste it!"

"If you can't even taste it," Mr. Bugles said, tilting his googly-eyed head, "then why is it in there?"

"Because!" Momma Karen said, as if that explained everything.

Chelsie took a brave forkful. She chewed. She chewed some more. She tilted her head, then tilted it the other way.

"Well?" Momma Karen leaned in.

"It tastes like a brownie that's keeping a secret," Chelsie said.

"A DARK secret," Mr. Bugles added. "A secret that should stay buried. Under the snow. Forever."

Momma Karen looked at the cake, then at the snow outside, then back at the cake. Her shoulders slumped just a little. Chelsie noticed, and something tugged at her heart.

Chelsie hopped off her stool and walked over to Momma Karen, Mr. Bugles swinging gently at her side.

"Momma Karen? How come you love chicken liver spread so much anyway?"

Momma Karen's eyes went soft and faraway. "When I was a little girl — even littler than you — my mother used to make it on snow days. We'd sit by the window and eat

The kitchen got very quiet. Even Mr. Bugles didn't say a word, which might have been a world record.

Chelsie looked at the original plate of chicken liver toast, still sitting on the counter. No whipped cream. No cake. Just the plain, simple spread the way Momma Karen's mother used to make it.

"Can I try it one more time?" Chelsie asked. "The regular way?"

She took a real bite this time — not a tiny, scared one, but an honest bite. She chewed slowly. It was salty, and savory, and kind of rich, and... actually not terrible?

"It's not my favorite," Chelsie said honestly. "But I get why it's yours."

Momma Karen's face broke into the biggest, warmest smile. She wrapped Chelsie in a hug that smelled like chocolate frosting and kitchen adventures.

"That," Momma Karen said, "is the nicest thing anyone has ever said about my chicken liver spread."

"Don't get used to it," Mr. Bugles muttered. "I'm still calling my lawyer."

They all laughed — the kind of deep, belly laugh that fogs up kitchen windows. Momma Karen made Chelsie a grilled cheese sandwich (because grandmothers always have a backup plan), and they sat together by the window, watching the snow pile higher and higher.

Momma Karen ate her chicken liver toast. Chelsie ate her grilled cheese. And Mr. Bugles ate exactly nothing because he was a sock, but he had a lot of opinions about both.

"You know what, kid?" Mr. Bugles said, watching the snowflakes fall. "Today was weird. The food was suspicious. But this? Sitting here with your crazy grandmother watching the snow?" He paused. "This is pretty perfect."

And for once, everybody — even Momma Karen — agreed with Mr. Bugles.

The End.

What food would you never want to try? What if someone added your favorite thing to it?

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